Additionally, according to Paul E. Mueller–Ortega, a modern scholar of Abhinavagupta (950–1016 CE), who was a polymathic Kashmiri Shaivite philosopher known for, among other things, his theory of aesthetics and for being the author of the treatise *Tantraloka*,

> Hindu Tantra rejects the dry vistas of traditional philosophical debate, which seek only the representation of the Ultimate [or *Brahman*] through conceptual truths. It rejects as well the self-enclosing renunciation of traditional Indian monasticism, which protectively seeks to isolate the monk from the imagined strain of worldliness. Transcending the dualities and distinctions of conventional thought and morality, the Tantra demonstrates an outward gesture of embracing delight in all of reality. The Tantric hero pushes outward into adventurous, spiritual exploration, into savoring and delighting the experience of so many varieties of blissful *ekarasa*, the unitary taste of consciousness.[43]

Tantric rituals, writes Thapar, were not only 'contrary to Vedic Brahmanism' but often 'a deliberate reversal of upper-caste practice'. Tantra was also 'open to all castes and included women in the rituals . . . Goddesses were accorded great veneration [and] the Devi, or the goddess, had an individuality of her own and was worshipped for this rather than merely as a consort of a god'. This, claims Thapar, didn't sit well with Brahminical patriarchy, or the fact that 'women were permitted to establish their own *ashramas*, to act as priestesses and to teach'. As for upper-caste practices like sati, the *Mahanirvana Tantra* declares that, 'A wife should not be burnt with her dead husband. Every woman is the embodiment of the goddess. That woman who in her delusion ascends the funeral pyre of her husband, shall go to hell.'[44] This Tantric substrate was partly fed by emerging subaltern groups and 'sections of society that had hardly known the Hinduism formulated by the Brahmans'. If the Chandelas did have a subaltern lineage, that would only have raised their psychological affinity for Tantra. Thapar adds:

> Those desirous of joining a Tantric sect had to be initiated by a guru. Tantric ritual involved the ritual partaking of the five Ms—*madya*, alcohol, *matsya*, fish, *mamsa*, flesh, *mudra*, gestures, and *maithuna*, coition. In the final state of purification everything and everyone was equal. The ritual being what it was, secret meetings became necessary, especially when some other sects denounced its practices as being depraved. Gradually there was a bifurcation into the Left-Hand path that experimented with these practices, and the Right-Hand path that restricted itself to yoga and *bhakti*. Although Tantrism has often been condemned for its more extreme activities, it seems also to have been a vehicle for opposition to the Brahmanical ordering of society.[45]